

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SOUTH SUDAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in South Sudan turns above all on a single vast and living thing — the **Sudd**, Africa's largest freshwater wetland, a green immensity where the White Nile spreads across the land, sustaining one of the world's great animal migrations and the cattle-herding peoples who have lived by its rhythms for centuries — and on the threats that press upon it: the **Jonglei Canal**, the half-dug megaproject that would drain it, now threatened with revival; the oil whose pollution seeps into its waters; and the catastrophic floods that climate has loosed upon it. South Sudan is the world's newest nation, born in 2011 into fragility and conflict, a land of wetland and savannah and oilfield whose defining environmental reality is the fate of the Sudd — a wetland of global importance, caught between those who would drain it for water downstream, the oil that stains it, and the floods that drown it. Notably, the environment ministry has itself declared it will not approve the canal that would drain the great wetland. The tools a community can use — running through what functions and the international — are real.

In a fragile, conflict-affected nation, the tools run through what functions, the international, and — where safe — the community, used with care and protecting everyone. The distinctive lever is the defence of the **Sudd against the canal**: the great wetland is a Ramsar site of global importance, and it can be defended — and the canal kept stalled — through the **Ramsar and conservation frameworks**, through the **environment ministry's own declared opposition** to the canal, and through the **evidence-based case** that draining the wetland would be catastrophic. The **oil's pollution** can be documented and confronted through the pollution and health evidence. The **living value of the Sudd** is a powerful argument: it sustains the great animal migration and the cattle-herding peoples, worth far more alive than drained. And the **international and UN frameworks, the conservation bodies, and the functioning institutions** offer real channels even a fragile state affords. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The nation is fragile and parts of it insecure and dangerous, so the work must run through what functions and with real care, protecting everyone. The canal's revival is pressed by powerful downstream interests who want the water. The oil is the economic mainstay. The floods are severe and climate-driven, beyond South Sudan's power, and demand a humanitarian response the world must support. And progress is slow and partial. And though the Sudd is the defining fight, the same toolkit reaches any other harmful project — the environmental assessment, the functioning institutions and courts, and the international and conservation channels — with the great wetland the central case. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the canal kept stalled through the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's own stand, and the evidence; the oil's pollution documented and confronted; the Sudd's living value defended — through the internal, international, UN, and conservation channels, and the communities where safe, protecting everyone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You defend the Sudd, in a fragile nation, through what functions and the world. Keep the Jonglei Canal stalled through the Ramsar and conservation frameworks, the environment ministry's own declared opposition, and the evidence that draining the great wetland would be catastrophic; document and confront the oil's pollution through the health evidence; press the living value of a wetland worth far more alive than drained; and work the international, UN, and conservation channels, and the communities where safe — all with care, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

South Sudan is a fragile, conflict-affected setting, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The nation is young and parts of it insecure, so the work runs through what functions and with care; the canal's revival is pressed by powerful downstream interests; the oil is the economic mainstay; and the floods are climate-driven and beyond the nation's power. So the realistic aim is not a swift victory but the canal kept stalled, the oil's pollution documented and confronted, and the Sudd's living value defended — through the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's own stand, the evidence, and the international and UN channels, while everyone is protected.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Authority in a fragile state is uneven, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through what functions and the world: the **environment ministry**, which has itself opposed the canal; the **functioning institutions and the government** where they act; the **Ramsar and conservation frameworks** that protect the Sudd; and the **international and UN bodies and donors**. The communities, where safe, hold real standing over the wetland they live by. Map who decides the Sudd's fate — the ministry, the frameworks, the international bodies — before spending a week on it.

How the Threat Moves — and Where You Jump In

The threats to the Sudd move differently: the canal is pressed by downstream interests but stalled; the oil pollution seeps from the fields; the floods come with the climate. You enter through the Ramsar and conservation frameworks and the environment ministry's own opposition to keep the canal stalled; through the pollution and health evidence to confront the oil; through the living-value argument for the whole wetland; and through the international, UN, and conservation channels. Enter through what functions, carefully, and protect everyone.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the canal: which downstream interests press its revival, and how the Ramsar frameworks and the ministry's opposition stand against it. Follow the oil: the pollution that seeps into the Sudd, and the health harm it does. Follow the wetland: the migration and the cattle-herding peoples it sustains, worth more alive than drained. Follow the water: what draining the Sudd would take and give. The leverage lies in the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's opposition, the evidence, and the living value.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here, in a fragile state, are the environment ministry that opposes the canal, the functioning institutions where they act, the Ramsar and conservation bodies, and the international and UN frameworks and donors. A case engages these, from within what functions and from the world, defending the Sudd through the frameworks, the ministry's stand, and the evidence.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No South Sudanese effort wins swiftly in a fragile, conflict-affected nation, and honesty requires saying so. What the careful tools can deliver is the canal kept stalled, the oil's pollution documented and confronted, and the Sudd's living value defended. The single most decisive move is **keeping the Jonglei Canal stalled**

through the Ramsar frameworks, the environment ministry's own opposition, and the evidence that draining the Sudd would be catastrophic, because the wetland's global standing, a functioning ministry's own stand against the canal, and the overwhelming evidence are a powerful combination. The Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's opposition, and the evidence are the distinctive levers; the pollution evidence the oil's confrontation; the living value the whole wetland's defence. The realistic prize is a great wetland kept from draining, pursued through what functions.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the threat?** — the canal's revival, the oil's pollution, the floods' damage. **What protects the Sudd?** — the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's opposition, the evidence. **What documents the oil?** — the pollution and health evidence. **What is the living value?** — the migration and the cattle-herding peoples the wetland sustains. **How is everyone protected?** — the overriding question in a fragile state. Pick the fight where the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's stand, and the evidence give the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers, carefully. **Layer one: the threat** — the canal's revival, the oil's pollution, documented with the science and the record. **Layer two: the framework and the value** — the Ramsar and conservation protections, the environment ministry's own opposition, the evidence that draining the Sudd would be catastrophic, and the wetland's living value. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which functioning, international, or safe community channel to engage, and the discipline of protecting everyone and centring on what is safe. A case built on the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's own stand, and the overwhelming evidence is one that even a fragile state's functioning institutions and the world can act on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **threat record**: the canal's revival plans, the oil's pollution, the science. Gather the **framework record**: the Ramsar designation, the conservation protections, the environment ministry's declared opposition. Gather the **evidence record**: the catastrophic case against draining the Sudd, the oil's pollution and health harm. Gather the **value record**: the migration and the cattle-herding livelihoods the wetland sustains. Gather the **channel record**: the functioning institutions, the international and UN bodies, the safe communities. The wetland's global standing makes much of this documented and available.

STEP 3: BUILDING SUPPORT THROUGH WHAT FUNCTIONS

In a fragile state, the effort centres on what functions and the world. Build with the **environment ministry and functioning institutions**, which have themselves opposed the canal; the **Ramsar and conservation bodies**, who protect the Sudd's global standing; the **international and UN frameworks and donors**; and the **communities**, where it is safe, who live by the wetland. Frame everything around the defence of the great wetland — its migration, its peoples, its global importance — worth far more alive than drained; protect everyone; and centre on what is safe.

STEP 4: THE RAMSAR FRAMEWORKS, THE MINISTRY'S STAND & THE EVIDENCE — DEFENDING THE SUDD

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by fragility and conflict, so the prize is the canal stalled and the pollution confronted, not a swift victory.

The Ramsar Frameworks and the Ministry's Opposition

The distinctive lever is the defence of the **Sudd against the canal** through the **Ramsar and conservation frameworks** — the wetland is a site of global importance — and the **environment ministry's own declared opposition** to the canal, a functioning institution's stand. Wield the frameworks and the ministry's own position to keep the canal stalled.

The Evidence and the Living Value

The **evidence-based case** that draining the Sudd would be catastrophic, and the **living value** of a wetland that sustains the great migration and the cattle-herding peoples, are powerful: it is worth far more alive than drained. Press the evidence and the living value.

The Oil's Pollution and the International Channels

The **oil's pollution** can be documented and confronted through the pollution and health evidence, and the **international and UN frameworks, conservation bodies, and functioning institutions** offer real channels. Pursued together — the Ramsar frameworks and the ministry's stand, the evidence and living value, and the oil evidence and international channels — these levers defend the Sudd, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always carefully. **For the environment ministry:** here is the canal you have already opposed, and the frameworks and evidence to keep it stalled. **For the Ramsar and conservation bodies:** here is a wetland of global importance under threat. **For the international and UN bodies:** here is a catastrophic drainage to prevent. **For the oil's confrontation:** here is the pollution and health harm, documented. **For the world:** here is a great wetland worth more alive than drained. **The golden rule:** keep the canal stalled through the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's own stand, and the evidence; confront the oil through the health evidence; press the living value; and work through what functions, protecting everyone.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a fragile, conflict-affected nation, and largely through international and conservation channels. Frame any attention around **the great wetland and its living value:** the Sudd, a wetland of global importance sustaining a great migration and ancient herding peoples, threatened by a canal that would drain it and oil that stains it — never in a way that endangers anyone. Carry it through the international and conservation press, the Ramsar and UN bodies, and the environment ministry's own stand. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the frameworks and the evidence; protect everyone; and let the wetland's global standing, the ministry's opposition, and the living value carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, framework- and evidence-grounded, and protective of everyone.

8A — To the environment ministry: reinforce its own opposition to the canal with the frameworks and evidence.

8B — To the Ramsar or conservation bodies: invoke the Sudd's global importance against the canal.

8C — To an international or UN body: present the catastrophic case against draining the wetland.

8D — On the oil's pollution: document the contamination and health harm for confrontation.

8E — On the living value: set out the migration and the cattle-herding peoples the wetland sustains.

8F — To a conservation partner: coordinate the defence of the Sudd's global standing.

8G — To a community source (where safe): gather testimony while protecting everyone.

8H — To the international public: tell the story of a great wetland worth more alive than drained.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the canal's revival or the oil's pollution; assemble the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's opposition, and the evidence; write the one-page case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the Ramsar frameworks and the environment ministry's own stand, and the international and conservation bodies. **Emergency action:** if the canal's revival advances, the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's opposition, and the catastrophic evidence are the sharpest, safest handles; for the oil, the pollution and health evidence. Throughout, work through what functions and protect everyone.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but fragile and conflict-affected. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a swift victory, but the canal kept stalled, the oil confronted, the Sudd's living value defended. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase: the Ramsar and conservation frameworks, the environment ministry's own opposition, the catastrophic evidence, the living value, and the international and UN channels. And accept the honest limits — the canal is pressed by downstream interests, the oil is the mainstay, the floods climate-driven — while still defending the great wetland through what functions, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CONFLICT — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption alone but a fragile state, insecure regions, and powerful downstream and oil interests. Respond through the **careful, functioning, and international channels:** the environment ministry that opposes the canal, the Ramsar and conservation frameworks, the international and UN bodies, and the communities where safe. Never in a way that endangers anyone, and never in the insecure areas without care. **On safety and protection:** this note matters greatly here and governs everything. South Sudan is a fragile, conflict-affected nation, its state weak and parts of it insecure and dangerous. Work through the environment ministry and functioning institutions, the international and conservation and UN bodies, and the communities where it is safe; protect everyone involved; and centre on what is safe and functioning. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, carefully and through what functions. The documented threat feeds the Ramsar frameworks, the ministry's stand, and the evidence at once; the oil's pollution feeds its confrontation; the living value and the international channels run alongside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the threat and assemble the frameworks, the ministry's opposition, and the evidence; **months two onward**, press the Ramsar bodies, the ministry, and the international and UN channels, and confront the oil; **through the long effort**, keep the canal stalled and defend the wetland. The core discipline: framework- and evidence-grounded, through what functions, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

South Sudan is a fragile, conflict-affected ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a swift or landmark victory, or that the fragile state and insecure regions allow open, easy work — none of that is true, and care for everyone is paramount. What it claims is real: that the Sudd, a wetland of global importance, can be defended and the Jonglei Canal kept stalled through the Ramsar and conservation frameworks, the environment ministry's own declared opposition, and the evidence that draining it would be catastrophic; that the oil's pollution can be documented and confronted through the health evidence; that the wetland's living value — the great migration and the cattle-herding peoples it sustains — is a powerful argument; and that the international, UN, and conservation channels and the functioning institutions offer real avenues. The levers work through what functions and the world, and the prize is a great wetland kept from draining, the oil confronted, and the living value defended — not a swift stop. For the world's newest nation and its greatest wetland, that careful work — through what functions, grounded in the frameworks and the evidence, and protecting everyone — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.